HCP 1559 (pc_hcp_240): Pepouš writes to Anna Tichá about a visitor

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered (221 cipher signs). 216 signs are read directly from the scan. One more is a faint trace read with low confidence. At the ends of two smudged words, four letters are restored from context and marked as such. Independent review 1 gave the verdict REVISE. The findings concerned record keeping and the marking of restorations, and all of them are addressed. The reading did not change. Report dated 2026-10-29.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1559 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1559). Its portal name is pc_hcp_240, and it belongs to the HCPortal collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-10-28, the portal listed it as follows:

- status **Not solved**
- tags Postcard and HCPortal collection
- category Substitution
- date 1903-03-29, language Czech, location Europe
- sender Unknown, recipient Anna Tichá
- no transcription or solution attached

It is an Art Nouveau picture postcard: a young couple and a winged child (a cupid) in a floral frame with clover ornaments. The card bears a printed red four-line verse in Czech that begins "V mém srdci pouze jedno přání". The verse is ordinary print, not cipher. The scan lies sideways; turned upright (90° counter-clockwise), the card shows the plain handwritten date **29./III. 1903.** (Sunday, 29 March 1903) beside the verse, and below the picture five rows of cipher text.

The address side is in plain writing: **Velectěná Slečna / slečna Anna Tichá / učitelka v / Žirovnici / u Počátek.** ("Honoured Miss Anna Tichá, teacher in Žirovnice near Počátky", South Bohemia). It carries a stamp and overlapping PRAG and ŽIROVNICE / SEROWITZ postmarks. No other cipher text was found on either side.

The card belongs to a family of cipher postcards to Anna Tichá, all in the same hand and the same cipher. They are signed "Pepouš", a pet form of Josef, and many of them are deciphered in this repository (for example HCP 1520–1527 and 1537–1556). The key used here was transferred from those cards (ciphers/hcp-1520/work/key.json). Maxim Egorov had earlier published a partial key for the family (https://maxim-egorov.dev/research/anna-ticha-postcards/). This card was therefore read with a **known, transferred key**; it is not a new key recovery. No reading of this particular card was supplied or consulted.



Picture side turned upright: the red printed verse, the plain date 29./III. 1903 and the five cipher rows below the picture (work/upright.png)



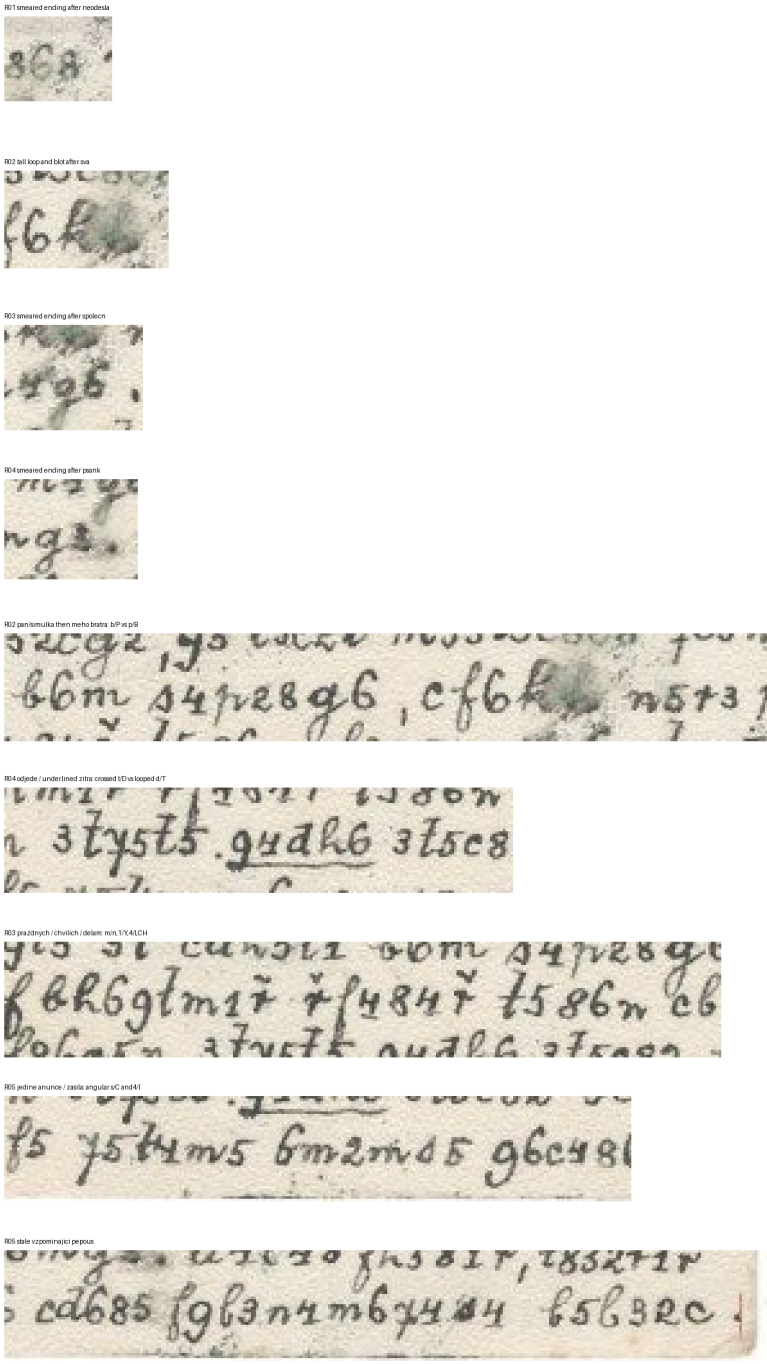
Address side: Anna Tichá, teacher in Žirovnice near Počátky (source/address.jpg)

Method

The transcription is **manual**. The solver read the five rows sign by sign from enlarged crops (work/R01.png to R05.png). No OCR was used.

The first working record left four smudged places as unknown spans of unknown length: the ends of the words NEODESLA-, SVA-, SPOLECN- and PSANK-. These places were then examined on 4–12× enlargements:

Place	What the scan shows	Reading
R01 after NEODESLA	A further two-lobed sign, the same shape as this hand's L. It is smudged but clearly visible.	NEODESLA**L** (read)
R02 after SVA	A clear k-shaped sign followed by a smear holding one dark stroke that cannot be identified.	SVA**G[R]**: G read, R restored
R03 after SPOLECN	Three sign positions before the full stop. Their shapes are too damaged to classify.	SPOLECN**[OST]** (restored)
R04 after PSANK	A small O-like trace before the full stop.	PSANK**(O)** (low confidence)



The four smudged places and the other control crops, enlarged (work/controls.png)

The k-shaped sign stands for G in this family. That value was not invented for this card: it is attested on other family cards, in SVAGRA (HCP 1541), TELEGRAM(Y) (HCP 1553, 1554) and KOLEGY (HCP 1570).

The restorations follow from the sentences:

- *švagr mého bratra*, "my brother's brother-in-law"
- *dělám společnost*, "I keep [him] company", the only idiomatic completion of *dělám společn…*
- *psánko*, "little letter", a word the writer also uses on HCP 1525 and 1526

A first reading of the R02 opening as KDE was corrected to ZDE. The correction came from comparing the shape against the Z of ZE and ZITRA and the K of DRAHOUSKU and SIMULKA on the same card (work/qg-root-control.png). It did not come from grammar.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution with one digraph sign. The labels are conventional names for the handwritten shapes, not exact reproductions. Several pairs are swapped against their look:

- `m` stands for N and `n` for M
- `t` (crossed) stands for D and `d` (looped) for T
- `c` (round) stands for S and `s` (angular) for C
- `b` stands for P and `p` for B

`y` labels the J-shaped sign, `H` the capped r-shape that stands for CH, and `G` the k-shaped sign.

Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain
1	Y	2	U	3	O	4	I
5	E	6	A	y	J	8	L
b	P	c	S	d	T	f	V
g	K	h	R	m	N	n	M
p	B	q	Z	r	H	s	C
t	D	H	CH	G	G		

Czech diacritics are not encoded: the cipher writes base letters only.

Frequency of each sign (221 in all, restored positions included):

Sign	Count	Sign	Count	Sign	Count	Sign	Count
1	4	2	10	3	15	4	14
5	25	6	17	8	12	y	6
b	10	c	20	d	7	f	8
g	4	h	10	m	12	n	9
p	1	q	7	r	3	s	5
t	16	H	5	G	1		

Plaintext

The transcription uses this notation:

- a plain sign is read from the scan
- `[..]` marks positions where ink is visible but the letters are restored from context
- `(..)` marks a faint trace read with low confidence

```
R01 bh3n4m, th6r32cg2, q5 t3c2t m53t5c868 yc5n t3b4c. y5cd
R02 qt5 3t cdh5t1 b6m c4n28g6, cf6G[h] n5r3 ph6dh6, y5n2q
R03 f bh6qtm1H Hf484H t586n cb385sm[3cd]. tm5c f5s5hm4n
R04 f86g5n 3ty5t5. q4dh6 3t5c82 bc6mg(3). d4c4s fh581H, t832r1H
R05 b2c cf5 y5t4m5 6m2ms5 q6c486 cd685 fqb3n4m6y4s4 b5b32c.
```

Literal Czech, as decoded:

```
R01 promin, drahousku, ze dosud neodeslal jsem dopis. jest
R02 zde od stredy pan simulka, svag[r] meho bratra, jemuz
R03 v prazdnych chvilich delam spolecn[ost]. dnes vecernim
R04 vlakem odjede. zitra odeslu psank(o). tisic vrelych, dlouhych
R05 pus sve jedine anunce zasila stale vzpominajici pepous.
```

The ZITRA of R04 is underlined on the card.

Normalized Czech (diacritics, capitals and punctuation are editorial):

Promiň, drahoušku, že dosud neodeslal jsem dopis. Jest zde od středy pan Simulka, švag[r] mého bratra, jemuž v prázdných chvílích dělám společn[ost]. Dnes večerním vlakem odjede. _Zítra_ odešlu psánk(o). Tisíc vřelých, dlouhých pus své jediné Anunce zasílá stále vzpomínající Pepouš.

English translation: **Forgive me, darling, for not having sent the letter yet. Since Wednesday Mr Simulka, my brother's brother-in-[law], has been staying here, and I keep him [company] in my idle moments. He leaves by the evening train today. _Tomorrow_ I will send a little letter. A thousand warm, long kisses to his one and only Anunka from her ever-remembering Pepouš.**

Slovak translation: **Prepáč, drahúšik, že som ešte neodoslal list. Od stredy je tu pán Simulka, švag[or] môjho brata, ktorému v prázdnych chvíľach robím spoloč[nosť]. Dnes večerným vlakom odíde. _Zajtra_ odošlem list(ok). Tisíc vrúcnych, dlhých bozkov svojej jedinej Anunke posiela stále spomínajúci Pepouš.**

Notes on the reading:

- **Jest zde od středy** ("has been here since Wednesday"): the card is dated Sunday 29 March 1903, so the visitor had stayed since 25 March.
- **Simulka** is kept without a háček. The cipher marks no diacritics, so a form such as Šimulka would be an editorial guess. The visitor's identity was not researched.
- **Anunce** is the dative of Anunka, a pet form of Anna. **Pepouš** is a pet form of Josef. **pus** is the genitive plural of *pusa*, "kiss". **jest** is the older, formal form of *je*.
- **ZASILA** keeps the cipher's I (*zasílá*, "sends").

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1559/work/decode-final.py
```

The script uses only the Python standard library and writes no files. It does the following:

1. Checks that work/key-final.json is exactly the family key of ciphers/hcp-1520 plus the one family sign `G`.
2. Decodes the manual transcription in work/transcription-final.txt, carrying the `[..]` and `(..)` marks through to the output.
3. Checks the decoded text against the final block in SOLUTION.md.
4. Prints the five literal rows and the line `CHECK: 5 rows; 221 cipher units = 216 read + 1 low-confidence (..) + 4 restored [..]; unknown spans: 0`.

The earlier verifier, work/decode.py, still checks the round-1 partial record with its four unknown spans (214 signs). It is kept for traceability. Neither script reads the image: the transcription step is manual.

Uncertainties

- **Restored letters.** R in ŠVAGR and OST in SPOLEČNOST are supplied from context. The sign positions are visible, but their shapes cannot be classified. The final O of PSÁNKO is a faint trace. The sense of the letter does not depend on any of them.
- **The cipher G.** The k-shaped sign occurs once here. Its value G rests on four other family cards, not on this card alone.
- **Smudges.** It cannot be decided from the pixels whether the four smudged places are accidental smears or the writer's own wiping. They are read as text, not as cancellations.
- **Identities.** "Simulka", the writer's brother and Pepouš himself are not identified.
- **Editorial choices.** Accents, punctuation and capitals in the normalized Czech are editorial.

- **Key.** The key was transferred from the earlier family cards and the published partial key, not recovered blind from this card. It decodes every legible sign here without change.

Review summary

The reviewer was Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), in a separate session from the solver. Round 1 gave the verdict **REVISE**.

What the reviewer checked:

- It ran the round-1 command.
- It decoded the transcription with its own script and the family key; the result agreed letter for letter.
- It made its own rotated crops and compared all five rows sign by sign; it found no discrepancy in the legible material.
- It confirmed the KDE→ZDE correction.
- It judged the four smudged places on 8–12× crops. It found NEODESLAL and the k-shaped G visible on the scan, R and OST restored from context, and the O of PSÁNKO plausible.
- It concluded that the reading as a whole is correct.

The five findings and what was done:

1. **(major) The command did not produce the claimed final text.** A final transcription with the four completions, a key containing the family G, and a new command (work/decode-final.py) were added. The status text in SOLUTION.md was reconciled.
2. **(major) Restorations were not marked.** All versions of the plaintext now bracket švag[r], společn[ost] and psánk(o).
3. **(minor) A háček had been added silently to the name.** The name is now Simulka, with a note.
4. **(minor) The U03 signs were described too confidently.** They are now described as seen but not classified.
5. **(minor) Stale "partial / unknown" wording.** It is superseded by a status note and a final section.

No decoded letter changed as a result of the review. The work was done in this order:

- The first, partial transcription and decipherment (four unknown spans) was made by OpenAI GPT (GPT-6 Astra / GPT-6.1 Sol).
- Claude Opus 5.5 completed the four spans and handed the card to review.
- After the review, Claude Opus 5.5 made the corrections, wrote this report and prepared the register entry.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1559, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-10-28: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1559 (source/metadata.md).
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/4737/conversions/pc_hcp_240_pic-large.jpg (source/picture.jpg).
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/4738/conversions/pc_hcp_240_adr-large.jpg (source/address.jpg).
- Family key: earlier Anna Tichá family cards in this repository, ciphers/hcp-1520/work/key.json; family G from ciphers/hcp-1541, 1553, 1554 and 1570.
- Maxim Egorov, Anna Tichá postcards, published partial family key: https://maxim-egorov.dev/research/anna-ticha-postcards/

- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-10-29: no entry for this card.